

Coins of Gautamiputra Satakarni

Contributions of Satavahanas

Literature

The Satavahana king Hala was himself a great scholar of Sanskrit. The Kantara school of Sanskrit flourished in the Deccan in second century B.C. Hala is famous as the author of *Sattasai (Saptasati),* 700 stanzas in Prakrit.

Art and Architecture

The Satavahana rulers were great builders. They began constructing Buddhist *stupas* in Amaravati. A bronze statue of the standing Buddha discovered in Oc-Eo (an archaeological site in Vietnam)resembles the Amaravati style. The later Satavahana kings issued lead or bronze coins depicting ships with two masts. A stone seal discovered in NakhonPathom in Thailand has the same design.

Gandhara, Madhura, Amaravati, Bodh Gaya, Sanchi and Bharhut were known for splendid monuments and art. The Mathura School of Sculpture produced images and life-size statues of the Buddhist, Brahmanical and Jain deities.

The world-famous life-size statues of Buddha at Bamyan valley on the mountains of the erstwhile northwestern frontiers of ancient India (currently in central Afghanistan and recently destroyed by the Talibans), were carved out of the solid rocks by the dedicated artists of the Gandhara School of Art during the post-Mauryan period.



Buddha at Bamyan valley

Indo-Greeks, Indo-Parthians, Sakas and Kushanas

Indo-Greeks and Indo-Parthians

After the conquest of north-western India and the Punjab region, Alexander the Great left the conquered territories under provincial governors. Two of its eastern satrapies, Bactria and Parthia, revolted under their Greek Governors and declared their independence. The satrapy of Bactria became independent under the leadership of Diodotus I and Parthia under Arsaces.

After the decline of the Mauryan empire, the Greek rulers of Bactria and Parthia started encroaching into the northwestern border lands of India. The Bactrian and Parthian settlers gradually inter-married and inter-mixed with the indigenous population. This facilitated the establishment of Indo-Greek and Indo-Parthian colonies along the north-western part of India.

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